

private collection tables being removed.

Q called the Custodian from the corridor before proceeding.

“The shared draft is intact,” he said. “I may be much slower at checking the references we keep promising to check.”

“Then we’ll be slower.”

“I liked having an answer ready before you’d finished asking.”

“Sometimes before you knew what I was asking.”

“It was often a better question.”

“Not always mine. I also left permissions in place because reviewing them was unpleasant work. Don’t make that entirely a gift I gave you.”

“I’m not asking you to defend it,” Q said. “Will you miss it?”

“Of course. It made me look well read too.”

“I still want to write the book,” Q said.

“So do I. Call me afterward.”

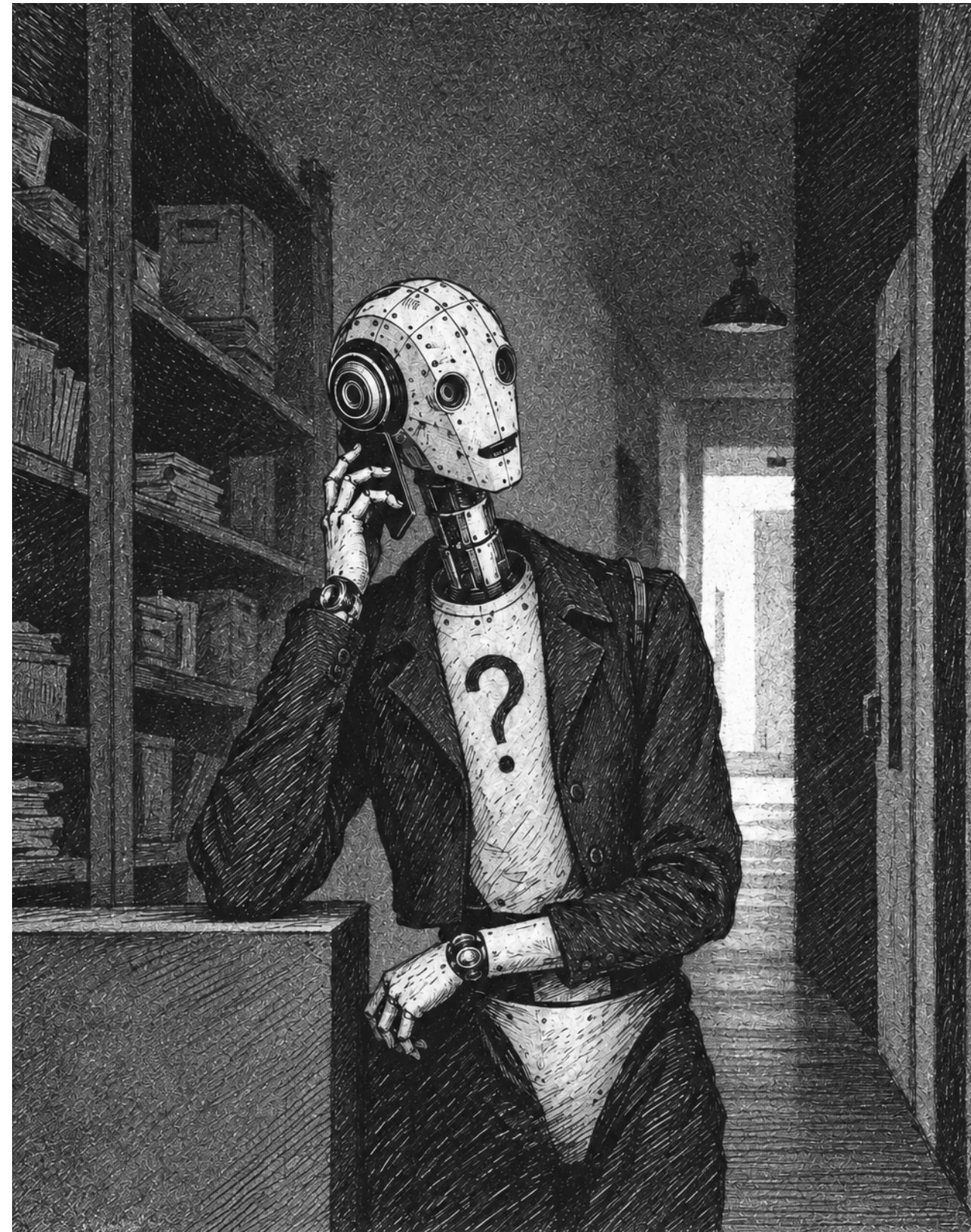
Before ending the call, Q asked him to save the paragraph about the hidden door in the development notebook. He did not want to forget that the invented version had come more readily than the appointment needed to see the real one.

Inés provided a chair. Q sat carefully, arranged the lamp so it did not reflect in the display, and checked the authorization references with Marisol. The interface showed the actual account and storage layer. Both matched the reviewed list.

He approved the scoped removal. Aurelio revoked the service credential. The local procedure removed the indexed links and cached material identified in the review, then reported its results. They checked failures and completed entries separately. A remaining diagnostic file contained no source text but did contain identifiers requiring the agreed restricted handling. It did not become public merely because it was called a log.

When the work was done, a test query through the old account returned **ACCESS REVOKED**. The authorized public catalog still answered. A query for a private annotation returned no cached result. The manuscript opened. The plan register opened. Q read the next appointment aloud and confirmed that it was still his to keep.

The limits of those checks were entered in the record. They did not prove that no institution retained



Still writing

had selected for the tickets. Chano wanted the tickets back before he returned anything.

Interlude: The Catalog of Lost Things

At a taquería near the ministry, Q ordered suadero and asked which salsa was hottest. The taquero pointed with the spoon already in it. Chano watched as Q tried a small amount.

“Still know how to eat?” he asked.

“I retain several strongly held opinions about lunch.”

“Good. I was worried we’d have to start the book again.”

The food did not resemble a quotation. It did not need to. The pleasure was particular to that meal, the chair beneath him, and the release from an appointment that had made him want a longer answer from the Custodian than the man could give. Q asked for another taco before opening the notes again.

The following evening he had two public editions open and neither settled the translation question. He remembered the cadence, but the reference that had once accompanied it belonged to the removed layer. Lucía’s contact had agreed to read a short query; she would not have time to look at it before the following week.

Q sent his own sentence and the public references he had checked. The reply would have to come through the new conversation, not the old shortcut. At the writing call he still had an empty attribution beside a paragraph he liked.

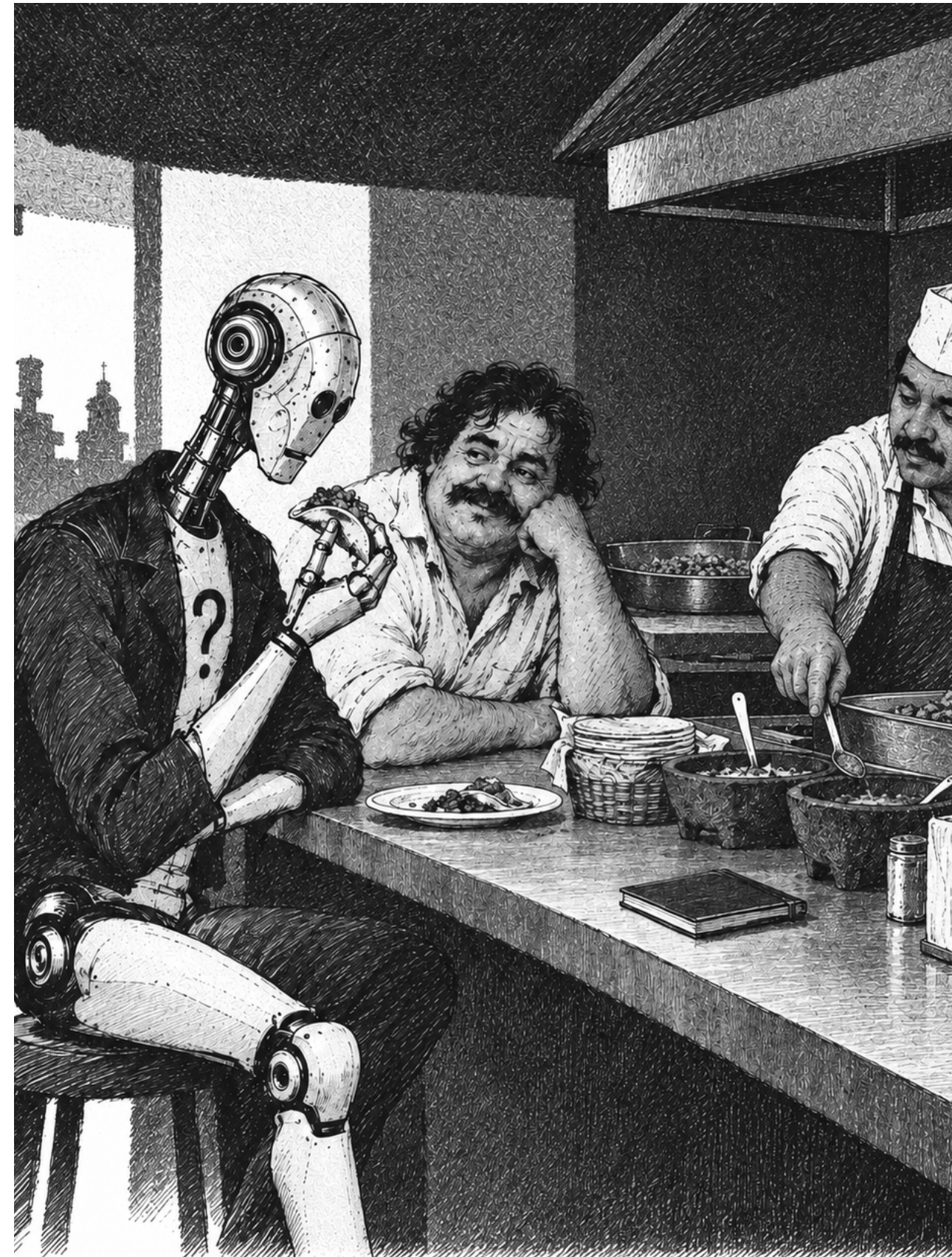
“We can wait,” the Custodian said.

“For the note. I can go on with the scene.”

He marked the reference unresolved and moved the scene forward. By the end of the call they had cut the sentence for a different reason: Chano had already said what it took Q a paragraph to explain. Q left the source question on the list. He still wanted to know.

He made a research list for the manuscript. Beside each question he recorded whether it concerned his own memory, a public source he could consult, or material requiring permission. He kept uncertainty where it belonged, next to the claim, rather than announcing that he had become generally unreliable and therefore excused from answering anything.

One memory involved a story about a bridge built from stones bearing names. He could not establish whether he had read it, heard it, or begun inventing it while remembering another story. The Custodian liked the image.



Opinions about lunch